



The Russian space station *Mir* (peace) provides a home for visiting astronauts. The first crew arrived on March 15.

killed a passenger, on October 10, when the hijackers abandoned the liner in exchange for safe conduct.

The **Siege of Gibraltar** ended after 16 years, when the Spanish government opened the border, on February 4. The dispute over the island's sovereignty continued.

British scientists discovered a **hole in the ozone layer** over Antarctica. Their findings, published in the May issue of *Nature*, rallied environmentalists.

Live Aid rocked the world in July with two huge concerts held simultaneously in London and Philadelphia to raise money for **famine relief in Ethiopia**.



MIKHAIL GORBACHEV
(1931–)

Mikhail Gorbachev became leader of the Soviet Union on March 11, 1985. He was the architect of glasnost (openness) and perestroika (restructuring). He built bridges with the West and renounced Stalinist ideas. He won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1990, but his policies led to the implosion of the Soviet Union.

KEY

- Highly contaminated area
- Broad range of radiation



Nuclear fallout

Following the nuclear power plant accident at Chernobyl, radiation spread across Europe as far as Paris.

WITH THE IRAN-IRAQ WAR IN ITS SIXTH YEAR, Iran launched a surprise assault and **captured Faw** in February. Iraq was accused of using mustard gas in its efforts to hold off the attack.

"**Irangate**," a scandal involving US president **Ronald Reagan**, came to light in October in the US. The Reagan administration had been selling **arms to Iran** to secure the release of US hostages in Lebanon. The profits of the deal were used to fund **Contra rebels** fighting the Marxist regime in **Nicaragua**. Reagan survived, but his chief of staff, **Donald Regan**, and national security adviser, **John Poindexter**, resigned.

US planes **bombed** military targets in **Tripoli**, Libya, on April 15. President Reagan cited self-defence to justify the move. Days earlier, US soldiers had died in a **bomb attack** at the La Belle disco in West Berlin, believed to have been ordered by Libya.

John McCarthy (b. 1956), a British journalist, was **kidnapped**

by Islamic terrorists in Beirut, on April 17. On the same day, three British hostages were killed in retaliation for Britain's support of the US bombing of Libya (see 1991).

Yemen experienced turmoil in January as power struggles within the **Yemen Socialist Party** (YSP) led to a **brutal war** between the north and south. Britain's Royal yacht, *Britannia*, helped evacuate British citizens.



Challenger badge

On January 28, the American space shuttle Challenger broke apart 72 seconds after take off, causing the death of all seven crew members.

The **Soviet Union** admitted to an accident at a nuclear power station in **Chernobyl**, Ukraine, on April 26. The accident was the worst disaster in the history of nuclear power. It released a high level of **radioactive contamination**, which spread to Europe.

Mir, the Soviet space station, was launched on February 20, as part of a **space city** to house cosmonauts. The first crew arrived on board the space station on March 15.

On June 12, **South Africa** imposed a **state of emergency** before the 10th anniversary of the black student uprising in **Soweto**. The government enforced curfews and banned television cameras from filming "unrest."

Ferdinand Marcos (1917–89) was forced to quit as **dictator of the Philippines** on February 25, after the military and a tide of world opinion turned against him. **Corazon Aquino** (1933–2009), the first female leader of the country, was sworn in as his successor.

Nearly **50,000 students** gathered in Shanghai's **People's Square** on 21 December, urging for more social freedom.

50,000
THE NUMBER OF STUDENTS WHO MARCHED IN SHANGHAI FOR DEMOCRACY



SWEDISH DEMOCRATS

Olof Palme led the Swedish Social Democratic Party from 1969. As prime minister he initiated major reforms and was an avid supporter of women's rights, healthcare, and welfare standards. His party was also a forerunner of green politics. He was accused of being pro-Soviet, which some thought led to his death in 1986.

Students all across China held demonstrations in major cities, demanding **democratic reforms**.

Spain and **Portugal** joined the **European Union** (EU) on January 1, taking its membership to 12. A new flag was also adopted as the official symbol of Europe.

The **Australia Act**, signed on March 3, made Australian law **independent** of the British legal system. It also transferred control of Australian constitutional documents into Australian hands.

September 3 Titanic wreck found
June 23 Air India jumbo jet crashes into Irish Sea
July 13 Live Aid concerts for Ethiopia in London and Philadelphia
November 13 Volcano erupts in Colombia
September 15 Anglo-Irish Treaty signed
December 11 Unabomber claims first victim in 17-year mail-bomb campaign in US

January 28 US space shuttle Challenger explodes
January 1 Spain and Portugal join EU
February 20 Mir, Soviet space station, launched
February 6 Jean-Claude Duvalier, dictator of Haiti, flees country
February 25 Ferdinand Marcos, dictator of Philippines, toppled from power
February 28 Olof Palme (b. 1927), Swedish prime minister, assassinated
April 8 Clint Eastwood, (b. 1930) US actor, becomes mayor of Carmel, California
April 15 US air strikes against Libya
April 14 Death of French philosopher Simone de Beauvoir (b. 1907)
April 17 British journalist John McCarthy taken hostage (released 1991)
April 26 Chernobyl nuclear accident
June 8 Kurt Waldheim (1918–2007) elected as Austrian president
June 12 South Africa declares state of emergency
December 21 Mass demonstrations held by students in China
November 29 Death of Cary Grant (b. 1904), film actor
December 29 Death of Harold MacMillan (b. 1894), British statesman